Ki Sisa 5784

It is a wonderful opportunity - and an obligation - to approach the many things we do on a regular basis, whether daily, weekly, monthly, or yearly, with renewed enthusiasm and deeper understanding. We shouldn't perform them like אנשים מלומדים, just going through the motions because we've done them our whole lives. Rabbi Oelbaum, זאל ער זיין געזונט און שטארק, has a unique ability to take things we do all the time and enlighten us as to how much deeper and more profound they really are.

One of the things we do every single שבת - found in פרשת כי תשא - is recite the following פסוקים (31:16-18):

וְשָׁמְרוּ בְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶת הַשַּׁבָּת לַעֲשׂוֹת אֶת הַשַּׁבָּת לְדֹרֹתָם בְּרִית עוֹלָם: בֵּינִי וּבֵין בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל אוֹת הִוא לְעֹלָם כִּי שֵׁשֶׁת יָמִים עָשָׂה ה' אֶת הַשָּׁמַיִם וְאֶת הָאָרֶץ וּבַיּוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי שָׁבַת וַיִּנָּפַשׁ.

There is a well-known מדרש on the words שָׁבַת וַיִּנָּפַשׁ. When the נשמה יתרה departs at the end of שבת, we recite a ברכה on בשמים. Why? Because שָׁבַת וַיִּנָּפַשׁ, and the מדרש says that the word וַיִּנָּפַשׁ can be read as וַוי אָבְדָה נָפֶשׁ - woe, the נשמה is lost! Since we experience a spiritual loss when the נשמה יתרה leaves, we smell בשמים to provide a small measure of תענוג to our נפש.

There is an interesting discussion in תוספות, brought down by the שפת אמת, that raises the following question: Is there a נשמה יתרה on יום טוב or not? We know that there is one on שבת. But what about יום טוב?

תוספות asks: If יום טוב falls on a Sunday, we do not make a ברכה on בשמים in הבדלה. Why not? Because יום טוב also has a נשמה יתרה, so we haven't lost it. However, if יום טוב has a נשמה יתרה, then why don't we say a ברכה on בשמים when יום טוב ends and we transition into חול? Or when יום טוב leads into חול המועד, which is also חול?

The שפת אמת offers an incredible חידוש. Yes, there is a נשמה יתרה on יום טוב, but unlike the one on שבת, it does not leave us. Why? Because יום טוב, as we all know, is החודש הזה לכם - it is מקודש by us. שבת, on the other hand, receives its קדושה directly from הקודש ברוך הוא. Every seventh day is שבת, from מעשה בראשית until today. But יום טוב is different - ישראל are מקדשים את הזמנים. And here comes his bomb חידוש: קדושה that comes through our מעשה never leaves. It stays with us forever! This is an astonishing concept. It reminds me of the famous debate between טורנוס רופוס and רבי עקיבא about whether הקודש ברוך הוא's actions are greater than Man's. רבי עקיבא answered that Man's actions are greater. טורנוס רופוס responded, "Oh, good answer! Because if you had said that הקודש ברוך הוא's actions are greater, I would have punished you for performing ברית מילה on הקודש ברוך הוא's creation. But since you said man's actions are greater, you proclaim that man has the ability to enhance and improve הקודש ברוך הוא's infinite creation." (I had the זכות to hear this מדרש from R' Ahron Soloveichik זצ"ל).

According to this שפת אמת, the קדושה that we instill into יום טוב, through our human effort, lasts forever! In contrast, the קדושה of שבת departs each week, and we need בשמים to compensate for the loss - וַוי אָבְדָה נָפֶשׁ - because we lost the נשמה יתרה.

In a real sense, פרשת כי תשא is a פרשה of קדושה. It discusses the לוחות, their breaking, the קדושה of שבת, and קדושה in various forms. שבת itself is a מקור קדושה. We always thought of שבת as the ultimate מקור קדושה - after all, the פסוק says (31:13) כִּי אֲנִי ה' מְקַדִּשְׁכֶם - talking about שבת. And yet, we have been given an extraordinary opportunity, granted to us by הקודש ברוך הוא, to generate קדושה on our own, to such an extent that it lasts forever.

https://youtu.be/06hS8JPNNLU